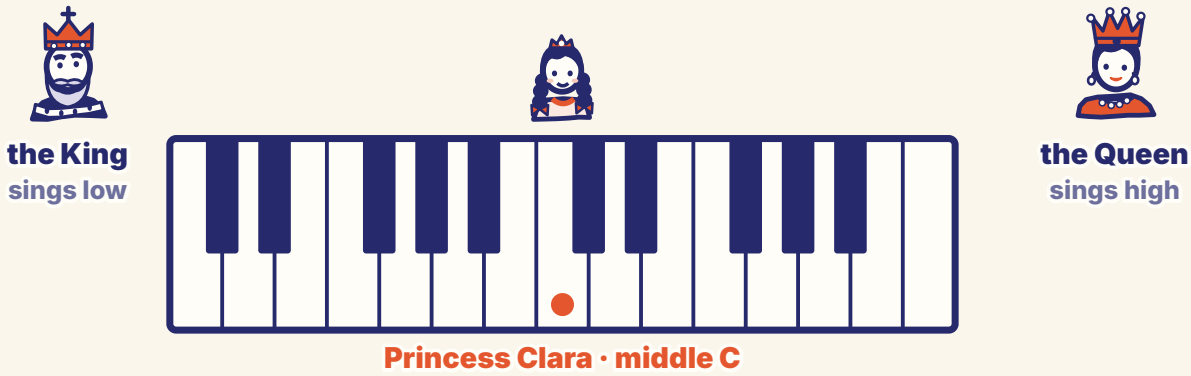
CHAPTER 4

Reading the Staff

Meet the royal family of the keys. The King sings low, the Queen sings high, and Princess Clara lives between them on middle C. This chapter writes their notes down, so your eyes can read what your hands play.



In this chapter

- ☐ Lines and spaces **page 2**
- ☐ Up the staff, up the piano **page 3**
- ☐ The Queen's five **page 4**
- ☐ The King's five **page 5**
- ☐ Middle C: Princess Clara **page 6**
- ☐ My five checks **page 7**

By the end, you can

- ✔ tell a line note from a space note
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- ✔ read C D E F G in the treble clef
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- ✔ find middle C on both staves -- attached up or down, the same key

ONLINE

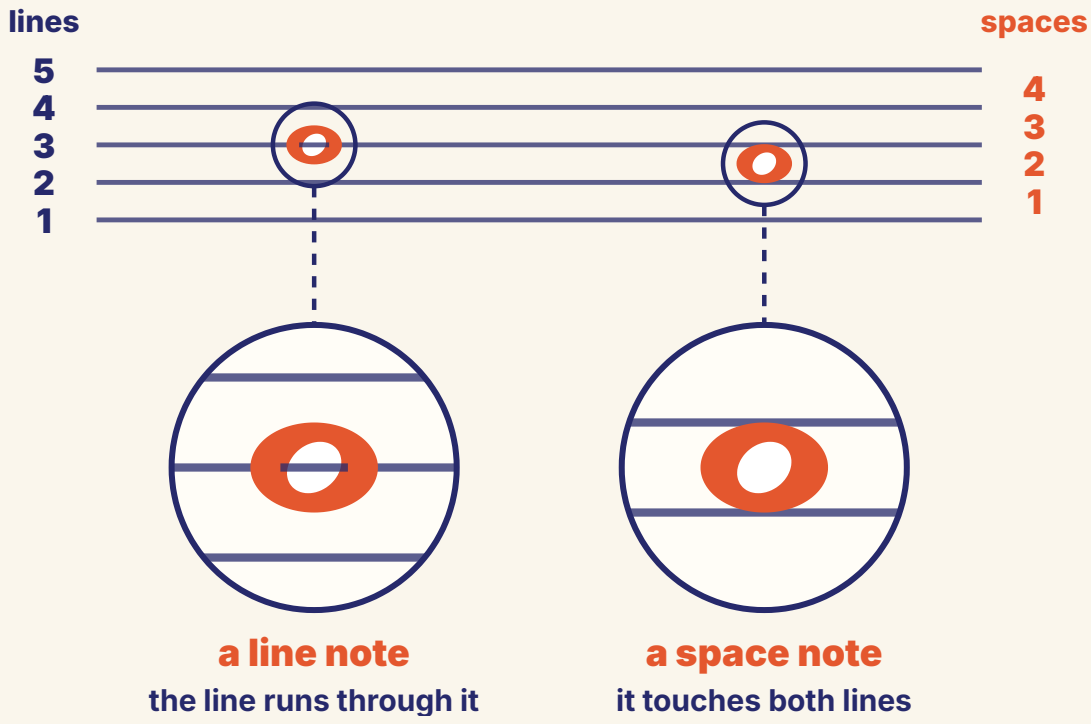
The lesson and the drill. Scan, pick a level, aim for 9 out of 10.

1. Line or space? __/10
2. Step or skip? Up or down? __/10
3. The Queen's five: C D E F G __/10
4. The King's five: F G A B C __/10
5. Around Clara: both staves __/10
6. Write it: tap where it goes __/10
7. Find it on the keys __/10

Step 1

Lines and spaces

The staff has **five lines** and **four spaces**. Count them **from the bottom**: line 1 is the lowest, line 5 the highest; space 1 sits just above line 1. Every note lives either **on a line** -- the line runs straight through its middle, like a kebab -- or **in a space**: it fills the space and touches the line above and the line below, like a sandwich filling.



Try it

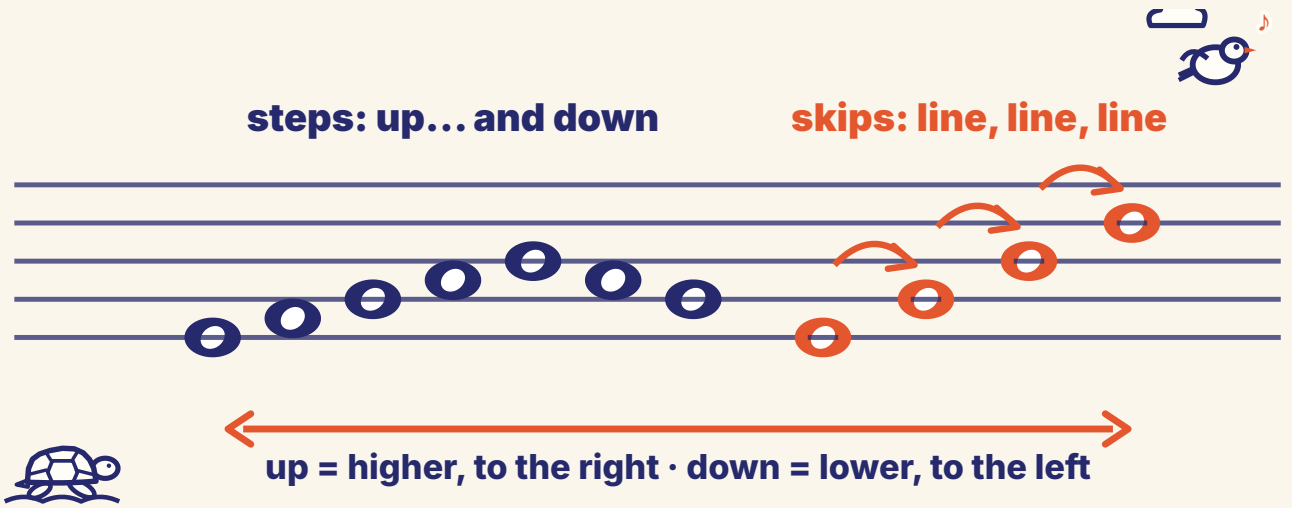
1. **The hand staff:** hold one hand out sideways, fingers spread: 5 fingers = 5 lines, the 4 gaps = 4 spaces. Someone touches one; say line or space, and which number. ☐

REMEMBER **On a line: the line runs through it. In a space: it touches both lines.**

Step 2

Up the staff, up the piano

The staff is a map of the keys. A note **higher** on the staff sounds **higher** -- it is further to the right on the piano, up towards the bird; **lower** on the staff is further left, down towards the turtle. From a line to the very next space is a **step**: the next letter, the next white key. From a line to the next line -- or a space to the next space -- is a **skip**: the same skip as in Chapter 3, one letter jumped over.



At the piano

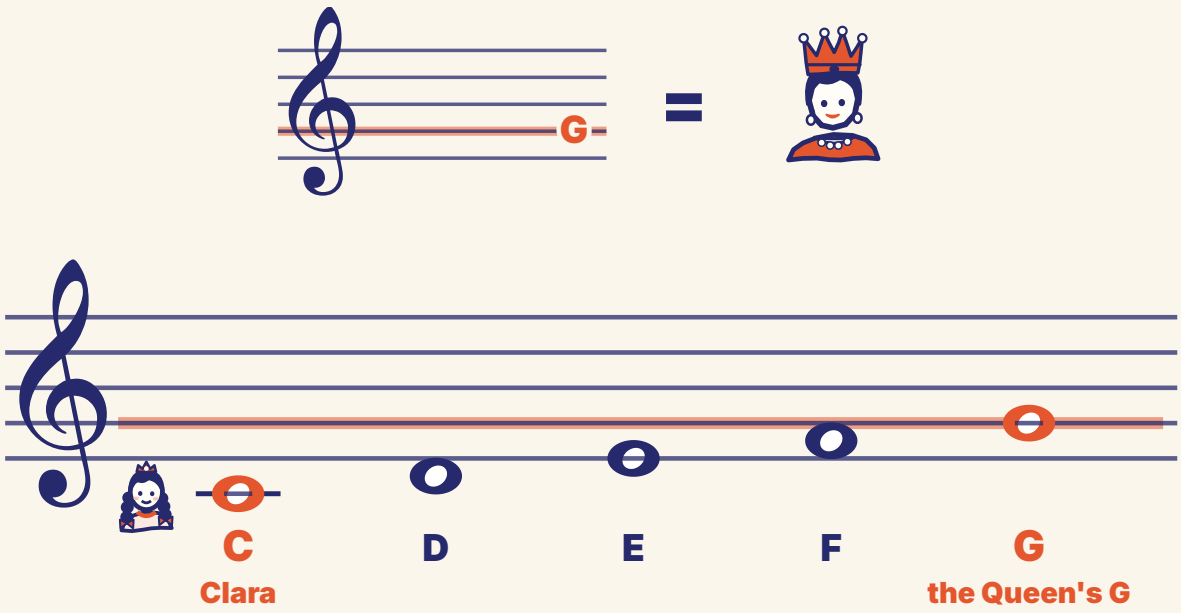
1. Start on any white key and play the picture's **steps**: up to the top of the hill and **back down** -- the next key each time. ☐
2. Now the **skips**: line, line, line going up -- a key jumped over each time. Then skip your way back down. ☐

REMEMBER **Line to space: a step. Line to line: a skip. Up or down.**

Step 3

The Queen's five

This curly sign is the **treble clef**. Long ago it was simply a letter **G**. Its curl wraps round the **second line** from the bottom, and that line is the **Queen's house**: every note on it is **G**. The Queen sings high, and usually the **right hand** reads her staff. From Princess Clara (middle C) up to the Queen's G is exactly **five notes**: C D E F G -- Clara on her little ladder rung under the staff, D just under line 1, E on line 1, F in space 1, G on the Queen's line.



At the piano

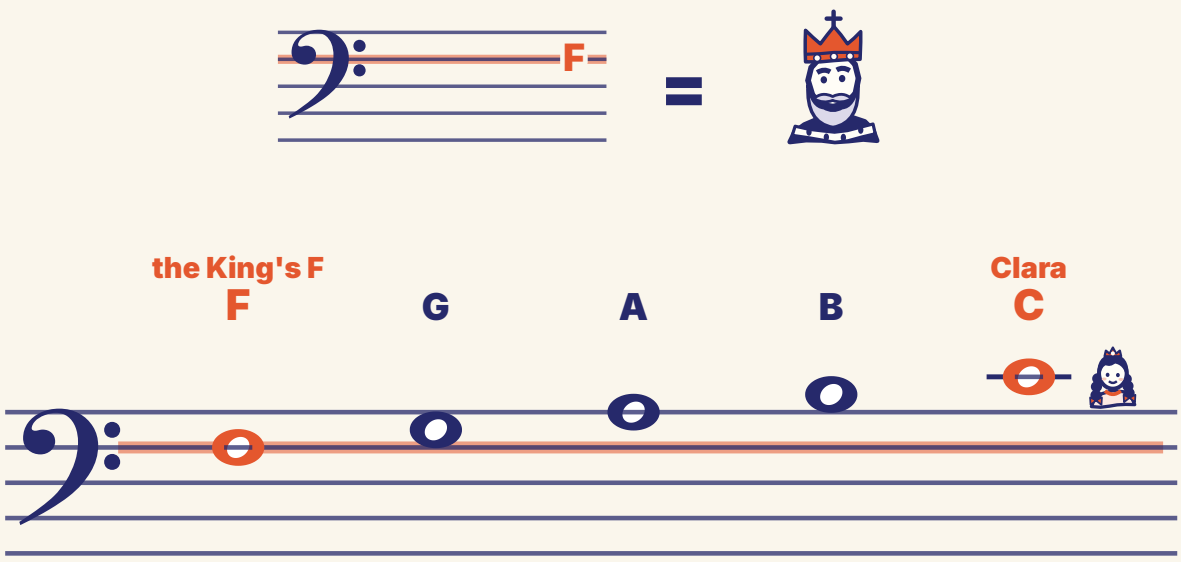
1. With your right hand, walk up from **middle C** to **G**: C D E F G -- looking at the staff picture, saying the letters. ☐
2. Someone points to one of the five: count down from the Queen's G or up from Clara's C, name it, play it. ☐
3. **Draw the Queen's curl:** a treble clef **starts on the G line** and spirals out -- it begins at the Queen's house! (The Workbook has one to trace.) ☐

REMEMBER **The curl wraps round G: the Queen's line. Clara to the Queen: C D E F G.**

Step 4

The King's five

This sign is the **bass clef**. It began as a letter **F**. The King's house is the **fourth line** from the bottom, and the clef's **two dots** are his guards, one just above his line and one just below. The line between the guards is **F**. The King sings low, and usually the **left hand** reads his staff. From the King's F up to Princess Clara is **five notes** too: F G A B C -- F on the King's line, G in the space above, A on the top line, B just over it, and Clara on her little ladder rung above the staff.



At the piano

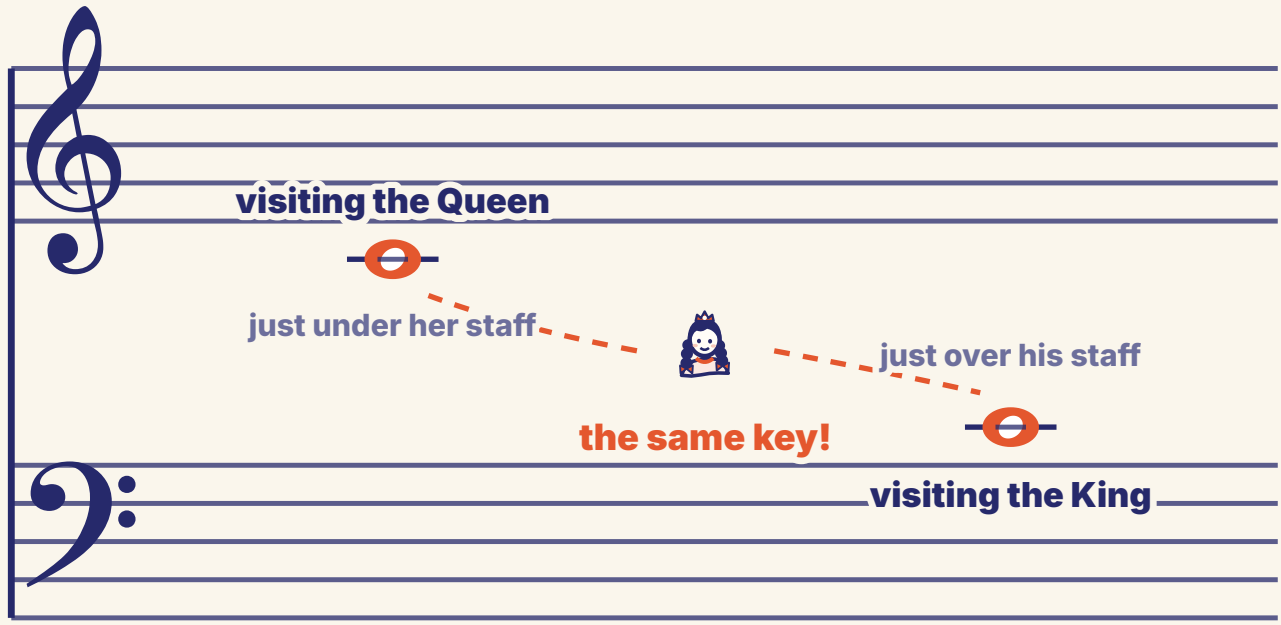
1. With your left hand, walk down from **middle C** to **F**: C B A G F -- then back up from F: F G A B C. ☐
2. Someone points to one of the five: count from the King's F or from Clara's C, name it, play it. ☐
3. **Draw the King's guards:** a bass clef **starts with a dot on the F line** and curls down -- then the two guards, one above the F line and one below. (The Workbook has one to trace.) ☐

REMEMBER **The two dots guard F: the King's line. The King to Clara: F G A B C.**

Step 5

Middle C: Princess Clara

Put the Queen's staff on top and the King's underneath, joined by a line at the start: that is the **grand staff** -- one staff for each hand. Between the two palaces, on **middle C**, lives **Princess Clara** -- the ground from Chapter 2. There is **one Clara**, and she has **one little ladder rung of her own**. **Visiting the Queen**, her note is written just under the Queen's staff; **visiting the King**, just over his. Two places on paper -- **the same key** on the piano.



At the piano

1. Play **middle C**: Clara's place, the one key both hands can reach. ☐
2. **Which palace?** Someone writes Clara's note under the top staff or over the bottom one: attached up or attached down, it is **the same key** -- play middle C each time, with the right hand and with the left. ☐

REMEMBER **Clara lives between the Queen and the King -- the same key on either staff.**

Check-up

My five checks

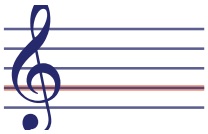
Show each one at the piano, then tick how it is going -- not yet, nearly, or got it! The check-up on paper is in the Workbook.

At the piano

		Not yet	Nearly	Got it!
	**I can tell a line note from a space note, and count them from the bottom**	○	◑	☆
	**I can see a step or a skip on the staff, and play it**	○	◑	☆
 C–G	**I can read the Queen's five: C D E F G in the treble clef**	○	◑	☆
 F–C	**I can read the King's five: F G A B C in the bass clef**	○	◑	☆
 C	**I can find middle C on both staves -- attached up or down, the same key**	○	◑	☆

Tick a box each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!

The royal signs





the Queen sings high -- her curl holds the G line. The right hand reads her staff.





the King sings low -- his two dots guard the F line. The left hand reads his staff.





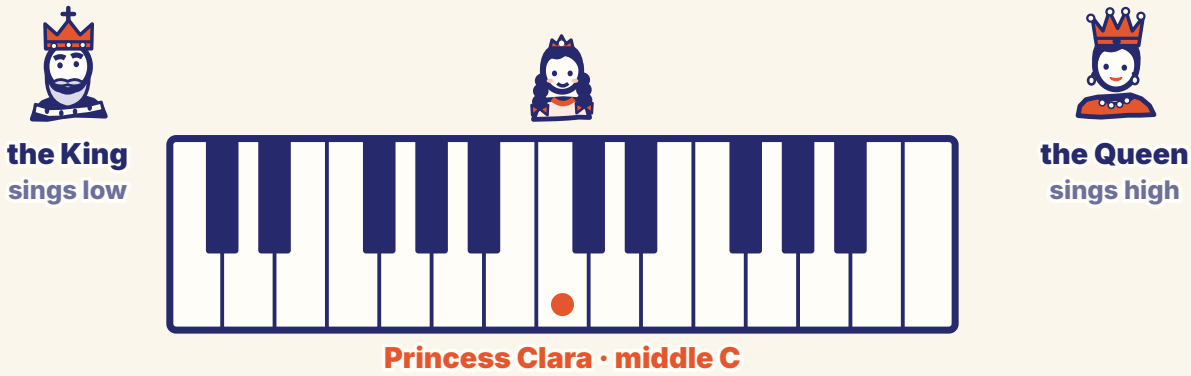
Princess Clara -- middle C on her little ladder rung, the same key from either palace.

Next: Chapter 5 · The Whole Staff -- every line and space on both staves, and the rhymes that go with them.

CHAPTER 4

Reading the Staff

Meet the royal family of the keys. The King sings low, the Queen sings high, and Princess Clara lives between them on middle C. This chapter writes their notes down, so your eyes can read what your hands play.



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- [ ] My five checks **page 7**

By the end, you can

- ✔ tell a line note from a space note
- ✔ see a step or a skip on the staff, and play it
- ✔ read C D E F G in the treble clef
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- ✔ find middle C on both staves -- attached up or down, the same key

ONLINE

The lesson and the drill. Scan, pick a level, aim for 9 out of 10.

1. Line or space? __/10
2. Step or skip? Up or down? __/10
3. The Queen's five: C D E F G __/10
4. The King's five: F G A B C __/10
5. Around Clara: both staves __/10
6. Write it: tap where it goes __/10
7. Find it on the keys __/10

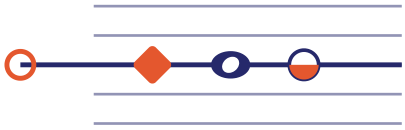
Lesson step 1

online

TRY IT Line or space?

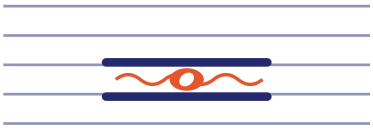
Kebab = on a line, write L. Sandwich = in a space, write S. Count from the bottom.

LINE note = a kebab



the line goes through the middle

SPACE note = a sandwich filling



it fits snugly between two lines

EXAMPLE



L

2



3



4



YOUR TURN Your turn

L on a line, S in a space -- then write the line or space number next to it if you can.

5



6



7



8



9



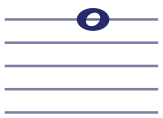
10



★ PLAY Kebab plate, sandwich plate

Sort the six notes: write each number on its plate.

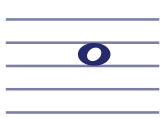
1



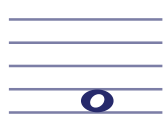
2



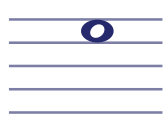
3



4



5



6



Kebab plate (line notes)	Sandwich plate (space notes)

Now cook your own

Draw three kebabs (line notes) and three sandwiches (space notes) -- anywhere on this staff, any order. Ask someone to point at each one and say which it is.

Lesson step 2

online

TRY IT Step or skip? Up or down?

From the first note to the second. Write it, like “step up” or “skip down”.

EXAMPLE



step up

2



3



4



YOUR TURN Your turn

5



6



7



8



9



10



11



12



★ PLAY Which is higher?

Circle the higher note in each pair -- then play both, low one first, and check with your ears.

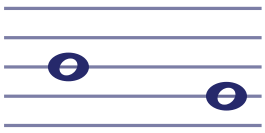
1



2



3



4



The staircase tune

The first note is drawn. Follow the signs left to right, drawing each next note -- then play your staircase with one hand and hear it climb and fall.
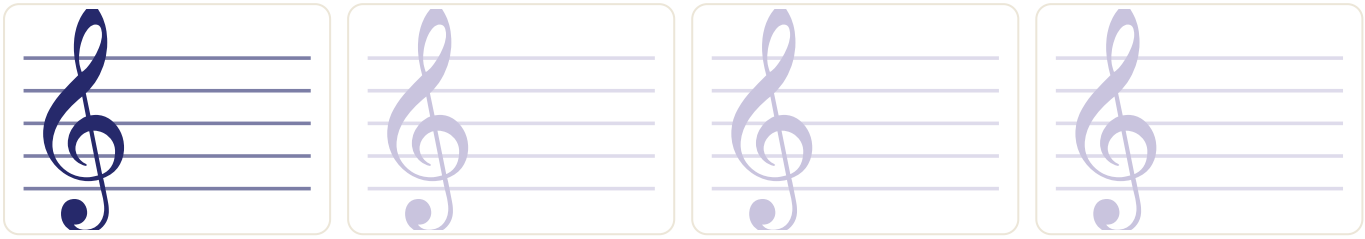


1 · step up **2 · step down** **3 · skip up** **4 · step up**

Lesson step 3

online

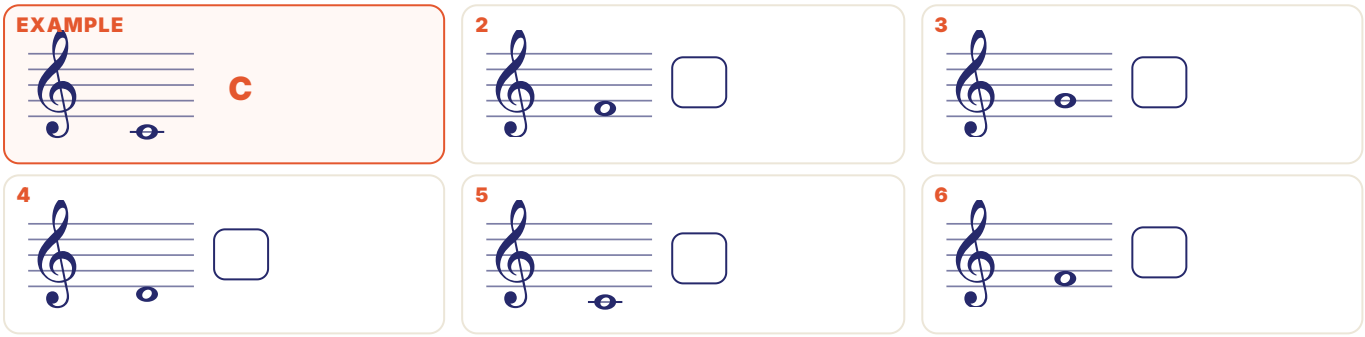
TRY IT Trace the Queen's curl

A treble clef starts on the G line -- the Queen's house -- and spirals out. Trace the faint ones.



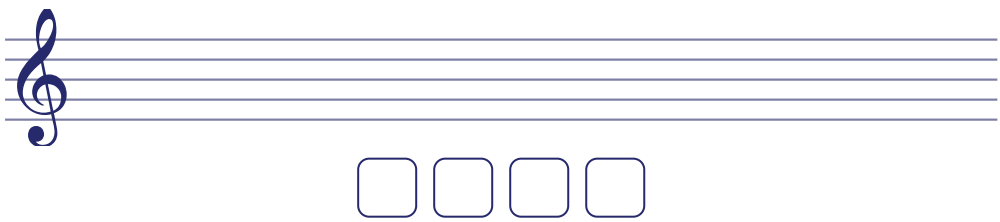
YOUR TURN The Queen's five: name the notes

Count up from Clara's C or down from the Queen's G.



★ PLAY Make a tune for the Queen

Draw any FOUR of her five notes on the staff -- your own tune! Write its letters in the boxes, then play it to someone with your right hand.



Give your tune a name: _____

Lesson step 4

online

TRY IT Trace the King's guards

A bass clef starts with a dot on the F line and curls down -- then the two guards, one above the F line and one below.



YOUR TURN The King's five: name the notes

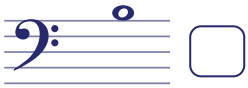
Start from the King's F -- the line between the two guards -- or from Clara's C.

EXAMPLE

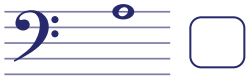


F

2



3



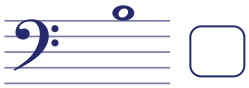
4



5

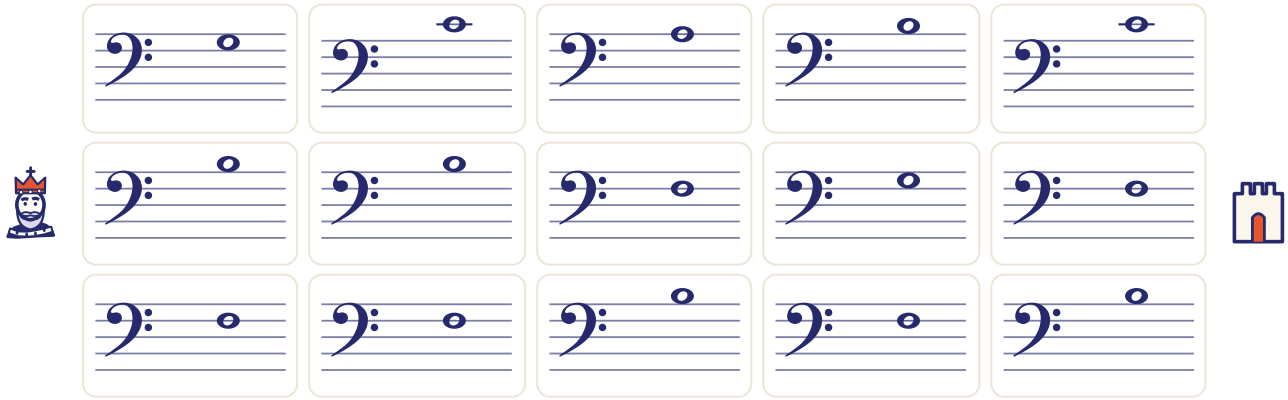


6



★ PLAY Help the King get home

Colour every F. The F stones touching each other make the road from the King to his castle.

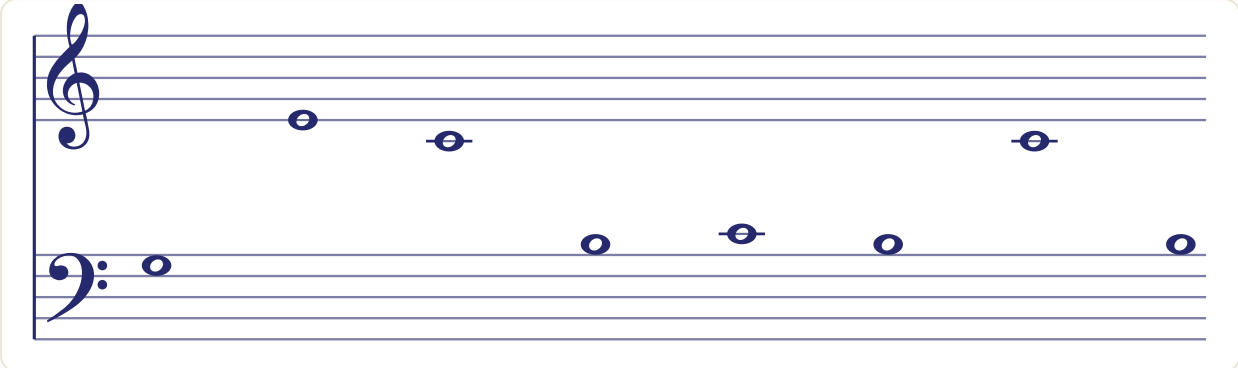


Lesson step 5

online

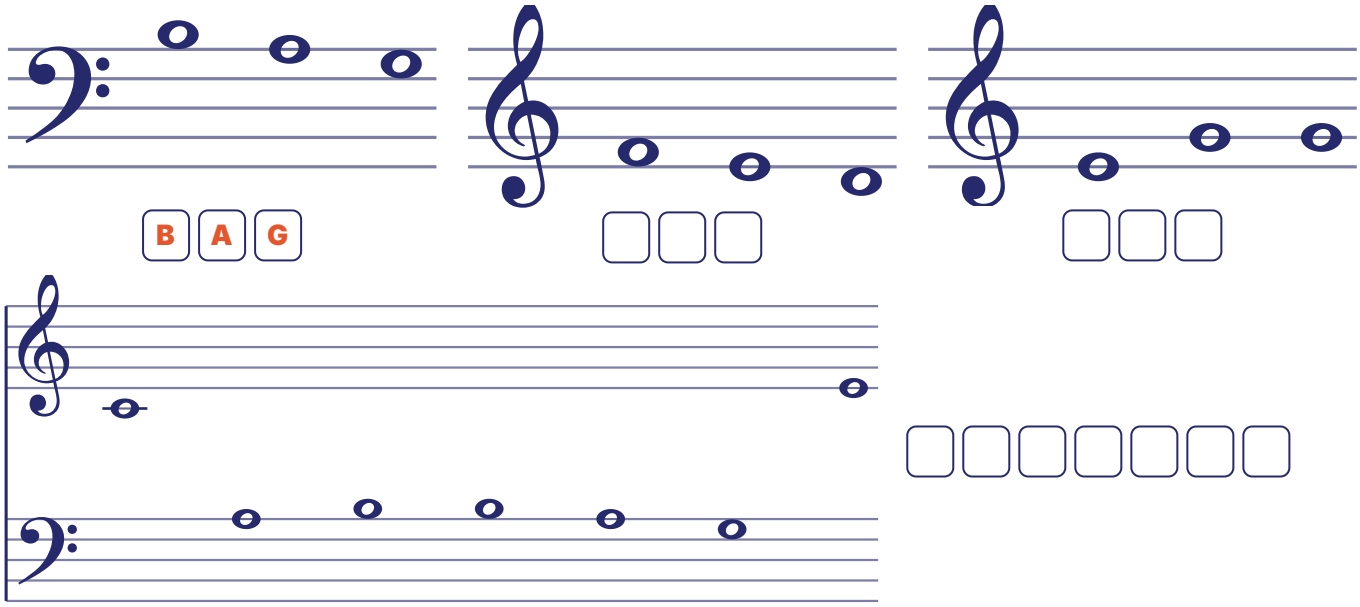
TRY IT Circle every middle C

Clara's note sits on its own little ladder rung -- just under the Queen's staff, or just over the King's. Same key!
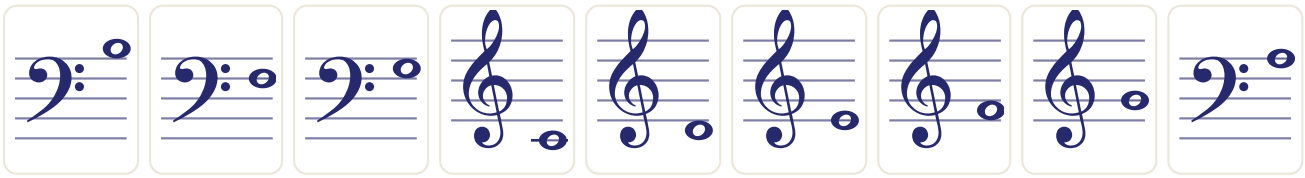


YOUR TURN The secret message

Write each note's letter in its box -- every row spells a word. The last one is seven notes long!



★ PLAY Note bingo

Someone names (or plays) one of the nine notes. Find it and colour it. Three in a row -- any direction -- wins!



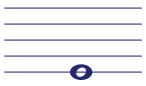
Lesson step 6 online

On paper

Name _____ Date _____ · no help, no piano · about 10 minutes

A Line or space? Write L or S.

1  ☐

2  ☐

3  ☐

4  ☐

B Step or skip? Up or down? Write it.

5  ☐

6  ☐

7  ☐

8  ☐

C The Queen's five: name the notes.

9  ☐

10  ☐

11  ☐

12  ☐

D The King's five: name the notes.

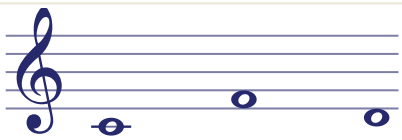
13  ☐

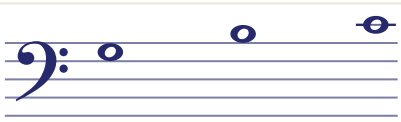
14  ☐

15  ☐

16  ☐

E Circle every middle C.





Check-up

My five checks

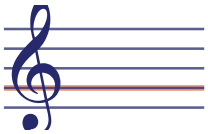
Show each one at the piano, then tick how it is going -- not yet, nearly, or got it! The check-up on paper is in the Workbook.

At the piano

		Not yet	Nearly	Got it!
	**I can tell a line note from a space note, and count them from the bottom**	○	◑	☆
	**I can see a step or a skip on the staff, and play it**	○	◑	☆
 C–G	**I can read the Queen's five: C D E F G in the treble clef**	○	◑	☆
 F–C	**I can read the King's five: F G A B C in the bass clef**	○	◑	☆
 C	**I can find middle C on both staves -- attached up or down, the same key**	○	◑	☆

Tick a box each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!

The royal signs

  the Queen sings high -- her curl holds the G line. The right hand reads her staff.

  the King sings low -- his two dots guard the F line. The left hand reads his staff.

  Princess Clara -- middle C on her little ladder rung, the same key from either palace.

Next: Chapter 5 · The Whole Staff -- every line and space on both staves, and the rhymes that go with them.

Teacher copy · Reading the Staff

Answers for every workbook page, the mistakes students make most, and a line to say when they get stuck. This chapter reads only the nine notes round middle C; the whole staff, the rhymes and fast reading from landmarks come in the next chapter.

p. 2 Lines and spaces

TRY IT 1. **L** 2. **L** 3. **S** 4. **L**

YOUR TURN 1. **L3** 2. **S2** 3. **L3** 4. **L5** 5. **S1** 6. **S3**

PLATES 1. **kebab: 1 2** 2. **sandwich: 3 4 5 6** 3. **own staff: any 3 line + 3 space notes, each checked against its own look**

Watch for
Counting from the top line down, and space notes drawn leaning on a line so they look like line notes.

If stuck, try saying
"Count like climbing a ladder -- from the floor up. Line 1 is the bottom one."

p. 3 Up the staff, up the piano

TRY IT 1. **step up** 2. **skip down** 3. **skip down** 4. **skip down**

YOUR TURN 1. **step up** 2. **step up** 3. **skip down** 4. **skip down** 5. **step up** 6. **step up** 7. **step down** 8. **skip up**

HIGHER 1. **2nd** 2. **1st** 3. **1st** 4. **2nd**

STAIRS 1. **line 2** 2. **space 1** 3. **space 2** 4. **line 3**

Watch for
Circling the note that comes later in time instead of the higher one, and calling every move "up".

If stuck, try saying
"Higher on the page is higher on the piano -- which one would your right hand reach for?"

p. 4 The Queen's five

YOUR TURN 1. **C** 2. **F** 3. **G** 4. **D** 5. **C** 6. **F**

COMPOSE 1. **any four of C D E F G -- check each drawn note against the letter written under it; then they play it**

Watch for
Starting to count without looking at the clef first -- most children grab whatever they remember.

If stuck, try saying
"Crown check first: whose palace is this? The curl holds the Queen's G -- start from her line, or from Clara's C."

p. 5 The King's five

YOUR TURN 1. **F** 2. **B** 3. **A** 4. **F** 5. **G** 6. **B**

MAZE 1. **the F road: row 3 col 1 › row 3 col 2 › row 2 col 3 › row 3 col 4 › row 2 col 5**

Watch for
Reading bass notes with treble names -- the answer comes out two letters too high.

If stuck, try saying
"Crown check: this is the King's staff. His two dots guard F -- find F first, then walk from there."

p. 6 Middle C: Princess Clara

CIRCLE 1. **staff 1: notes 3 & 5 & 7**

MESSAGE 1. **BAG** 2. **FED** 3. **EGG** 4. **CABBAGE**

BINGO 1. **B** 2. **F** 3. **G** 4. **C** 5. **D** 6. **E** 7. **F** 8. **G** 9. **A**

Watch for
Thinking the C under the treble staff and the C over the bass staff are two different keys.

If stuck, try saying
“Same key, written from the Queen's side or the King's side -- that is why Clara stands by both.”

p. 7 Check-up

A 1. **S** 2. **L** 3. **S** 4. **L**

B 1. **step up** 2. **skip down** 3. **skip up** 4. **step down**

C 1. **E** 2. **F** 3. **D** 4. **G**

D 1. **A** 2. **B** 3. **G** 4. **F**

E 1. **treble staff: note 1 · bass staff: note 3**

If a concept is not passed, go back to: **A** Lesson step 1, workbook page 2 · **B** Lesson step 2, workbook page 3 · **C** Lesson step 3, workbook page 4 · **D** Lesson step 4, workbook page 5 · **E** Lesson step 5, workbook page 6

Watch for
A wobbly B: step down from Clara's C. And F and G living in both palaces -- on the Queen's staff they are high, on the King's they are low.

If stuck, try saying
“Crown check, then count from the nearest friend: the Queen's G, Clara's C or the King's F.”

LESSON TIME The hand staff (page 2 of the book) is the one prop this chapter needs: five fingers are the five lines. Short lessons: set the drill levels as the week's practice -- random notes, a little every day, tracked on the student page.